

exegetical liberties: notice, for instance, the violent rendering in both of 1, 4, the artificial explanation of 3, 6-11, &c. Ew.'s view, even if not *certain*, remains still the best that has been proposed (cf. W. R. Smith).

§ 2. RUTH.

LITERATURE.—The Commentaries of Bertheau and Keil on Judges (p. 151), at the end; Wellhausen, *Comp.* pp. 357-359; W. R. Smith, "Ruth" in the *Encycl. Brit.*; S. Oettli in Strack and Zöckler's *Kgf. Komm.* (in the part entitled *Die Geschichtlichen Hagiographen*, 1889, p. 211 ff.).

The contents of this Book are too well known to need a detailed description. Elimelech, a native of Bethlehem in Judah, in the days of the Judges, goes with his wife, Naomi, and his two sons, Mahlon and Chilion, to sojourn in Moab. He dies there; and his two sons marry Moabitish wives, Orpah and Ruth respectively. After a while Mahlon and Chilion die likewise, and Naomi is left alone with her two daughters-in-law. She resolves upon returning to Bethlehem, but bids her daughters-in-law remain in their own country. Orpah accepts her mother-in-law's offer; Ruth expresses her determination to accompany Naomi back (c. 1). C. 2-4 narrate how it happened that after their return to Bethlehem, Ruth made the acquaintance of her kinsman Boaz, and how in the end he took her as his wife. The offspring of their union was Obed, father of Jesse, and grandfather of David. The narrative is told with much picturesque and graceful detail, and affords an idyllic glimpse of home life in ancient Israel.

Aim of the Book.—The Books of Samuel contain no particulars respecting the ancestry of David, merely giving the names of his father Jesse and of his brethren (1 Sa. 16, 1-13 &c.); hence the aim of the Book appears to have been partly to fill up this deficiency, partly (and perhaps particularly) to show how Ruth, a daughter of Moab, and a native therefore of a country hostile theocratically to Israel, obtained an honourable position among Jehovah's people, and became an ancestor of the illustrious king, David.¹ Has the writer, however, any ulterior aim, besides the one which is visible on the surface? Intermarriage with foreign women was one of the practices which Ezra (c. 9-10) and Nehemiah (13, 23-29) strove earnestly to suppress; and hence

¹ Keil, § 136; Bertheau, p. 283; Kuenen, *Onderzoek*, § 36. 9. Notice 1, 16^b, 2, 12^b. This reception of Ruth appears to conflict with Dt. 23, 3.

נָשָׂא *to take wives* 1, 4 (for the usual 'לָקַח נ', as 2 Ch. 11, 21. 13, 21. 24, 3. Ezr. 9, 2. 12. 10, 44. Neh. 13, 25 (in Jud. 21, 23 rather differently = *to carry away, secure*; Budde, *Richter und Samuel*, p. 154).

עָנָן *to restrain* 1, 13 (as *perhaps* in Aram.: but comp. Payne Smith, *s.v.*).

שָׁבַר *to hope* 1, 13, as Is. 38, 18 (poet.). Ps. 104, 27. 119, 166. 145, 15.

Est. 9, 1† (= Aram. סָבַר) : cf. subst. שָׁבַר Ps. 119, 116. 146, 5† (late).

יָרִי *Almighty* 1, 20 f. (without אֱלֹהִים *God*: p. 119, *note*), as never elsewhere in prose, and in poetry chiefly in Job.

מִרְגְּלוֹת *the parts about the feet* 3, 4. 7. 8. 14, only besides Dan. 10, 6.

לָפַת *to turn about* 3, 8, only besides Job 6, 18 (but Arab., not Aram.).

קִים *to confirm* 4, 7, as Ez. 13, 6. Ps. 119, 28. 106. Est. 9, 21. 27. 29. 31.

32, and in Aram. (Dan. 6, 8)†.¹

Of these קִים cannot be defended as old-Hebrew; but the word occurs in a verse which is not needed in the narrative, and has every appearance of being an *explanatory gloss* (cf. the gloss in 1 Sa. 9, 9, *which begins similarly*).

Of the others, מִרְגְּלוֹת is formed in exact analogy with מִרְאִשׁוֹת (1 Sa. &c.); its not occurring elsewhere till Dan. may be due merely to its not being required. שָׁרִי (which occurs in poetry in Nu. 24, 4. 16) may be a poetical term (cf. 2, 12^b) chosen intentionally by the author: poetical expressions occur from time to time in other pre-exilic historical books. In reference to the rest, it may be remembered that words, with Aramaic or late Hebrew affinities, occur, at least sporadically, in passages admittedly of early date (as תְּשׁוּרָה, אֹזֶל in 1 Sa. 9, 1—10, 16). לָהֵן is the word which it is most difficult to reconcile with an early date; but it is possible that the Book, in spite of its interest in Bethlehem and David, was yet written in the N. kingdom, and preserves words current there dialectically (p. 422).

It seems to the writer that the general beauty and purity of the style of Ruth point more decidedly to the pre-exilic period than do the isolated expressions quoted to the period after the exile.² The genealogy, 4, 18—22, which also appears to suggest an exilic or post-exilic date (הוֹלִיד [p. 127, No. 45]; and comp. 1 Ch. 2, 9 ff.), forms no integral part of the Book, and may well have been added long after the Book itself was written, in an age that was devoted to the study of pedigrees, in order to supply the missing links between Boaz and Perez (4, 12).

That David had Moabite connexions is probable independently from 1 Sa. 22, 3 f. The basis of the narrative consists, it may reasonably be supposed, of the family traditions respecting Ruth

¹ צִבְטָא (2, 14) is wrongly cited as an Aramaism. It is pure Hebrew = Arab. ضَبَطَ = Aram. ضَبَطَ (*Tenses*, § 178. 1). Nor is צִבְטָא (2, 16) an Aramaic word

² But, it is true, the style of the prose parts of *Job* (p. 405) is not less pure.